

Oxygen carriers

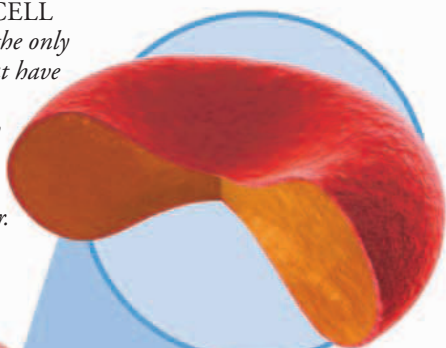
Red blood cells are by far the most numerous cells in your body. These amazingly hardworking cells have the endless task of carrying oxygen to all your body cells to keep them alive. This demanding activity means that about two million red blood cells wear out every second, so your body has to make new cells at the same rate to replace them.

WOW!

You have about 25 trillion red blood cells circulating around your body.

► INSIDE THE CELL

Red blood cells are the only cells in the body that have no nucleus. Instead, they are packed with hemoglobin—the reddish protein that gives them their color.



HARD AT WORK

Red blood cells are filled with the oxygen-carrying protein hemoglobin. As your blood flows through your lungs, hemoglobin picks up oxygen. Your blood transports this fresh supply of oxygen to all of your body's tissues, where hemoglobin releases the oxygen so that it can be used by your cells. Your red blood cells then return to your lungs to collect fresh supplies.

The cells are very flexible, enabling them to bend and squeeze along capillaries—the smallest of your blood vessels.

The dimple shape gives the cell a large surface area for picking up and unloading oxygen.

